Introduction

Soon after I joined the Indian Foreign Service in 1970, I was told I would be sent to Hong Kong to learn Mandarin, the standard Chinese spoken in Beijing. I was not particularly enthused. I knew little about China and even less about the language of that country. But I did know that China was in the throes of the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution that had unleashed widespread political violence in the country. Our own embassy in Beijing had been attacked, as had the British embassy. India's relations with China had remained frosty since the unfortunate border war of 1962. I was apprehensive about being thrown into this maelstrom of conflict once I had concluded my language studies.

My entire outlook towards China and the Chinese changed when I arrived in Hong Kong in 1971 and took up the study of Mandarin at the British Ministry of Defence School. My Chinese teachers were among the best, but more than their professional skills, what impressed me were their patience, consideration, and, over time, even affection. I learnt more Chinese from them outside the classroom than inside, spending weekends with them, going out to restaurants or just sightseeing in Hong Kong in their company. Learning Mandarin opened a whole new and fascinating world for me. I was coming face to face with a civilization with a long and varied history, a philosophical and cultural heritage of enormous richness, and a view of the world quite distinct and indeed different from others'. There were elements that were recognizably Asian – for example, the central role of family and kinship ties. But some were uniquely Chinese, like the language itself, made up of ideograms and without an alphabet. I discovered that China had a vast, almost inexhaustible store of written and documented history going back 3,500 years, with precise dating of events that occurred a long time ago. India had nothing comparable.

I spent a total of six years serving in China, first during the last phase of the Cultural Revolution (1974–77) and then during the early years of